

THE CASEBOOK OF TRIALS

Every prosecution this book describes, in order, with what the court did. Two entries are printed in bold because they are the ones a reader is most likely to miss and least likely to expect: in 1598 and again in 1603, a French sovereign court looked at a full confession of werewolfism and refused to execute the man who had made it.

When and where	The charge	What the court did
1440 · Nantes	Gilles de Rais, Marshal of France, charged with the murder of a large number of children at Machecoul and elsewhere.	Tried before an ecclesiastical court under the Bishop of Nantes and a secular one under Pierre de l'Hôpital. Excommunication was pronounced; a detailed confession followed on 21 October after torture had been threatened. Hanged 26 October 1440. Chapters XI–XIII.
1521 · Poligny	Pierre Burgot and Michel Verdun, charged as werewolves with the killing of children.	Confessed and were burned. Chapter VI.
1573 · Dole	Gilles Garnier, the hermit of Saint-Bonnot.	Confessed to killing and eating children while in the form of a wolf; burned. Chapter VI.
1598 · Franche-Comté	The Gandillon family.	Prosecuted by Henri Boguet, who wrote the case up himself. Chapter VI.
1598 · Angers, then Paris	Jacques Roulet, found near a mutilated body and confessing to lycanthropy.	Condemned to death, and the sentence set aside. The Parlement of Paris committed him to an asylum for two years instead. Chapter VI.
1603 · Bordeaux	Jean Grenier, a beggar boy of about fourteen who told girls on the dunes that he was a wolf and had eaten children.	Not punished. The Parlement placed him in a monastery on account of his youth and his condition. Pierre de Lancre visited him there in 1610. Chapter VII.
1849 · Polomyja, Austrian Galicia	Swiatek, a beggar, found to have killed and eaten children.	Never tried: he killed himself in custody at Dabkow. Baring-Gould names no source for the case. Chapter XIV.
1848–49 · Paris	The violation of graves in the city cemeteries.	A trap was laid and a sergeant of the army was caught and confessed. Chapter XV — and, as Baring-Gould says, an anomalous case: no wolf appears in it at all.

The two that are easy to miss. In 1598 the Parlement of Paris set aside the death sentence on Jacques Roulet and committed him to an asylum for two years. In 1603 the Parlement of Bordeaux declined to punish Jean Grenier at all and placed him in a monastery. Both had made full confessions to being werewolves. Both courts treated the confession as evidence about the man rather than about the crime — three hundred years before anyone would call that an insanity defence.

From The Book of Were-Wolves by Sabine Baring-Gould, Valice Classics 15. Free at valicepress.com companion book-of-were-wolves